THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE

English serves as a functional alternative language in several areas of public activity for the many nations of the world which use it as an international second language. Because of its widespread use geographically, and because of the large number of people who speak it, it has been adopted as the language of aviation and air traffic. English has continued as one of the important languages of commerce, as the sphere of political and economic influence of the English-speaking nations has extended far beyond their own boundaries. The use of English in international diplomacy is strengthened by its acceptance as one of the official languages of the United Nations. And as a final example, English is the language of the majority of published materials in the world, so that education, especially specialized higher education, has come to rely very heavily on an understanding of English. In no sense does English replace the cultural heritage and emotional ties of the first language, but for many speakers throughout the world, it provides a means of communicating with people of similar training and interests who would otherwise not be able to comprehend them.

EXERCISE 1: Find words or phrases in the passage which mean the same as:

COLUMN A **COLUMN B**

a) serving a useful purpose .....

b) choose or take up something as one's own .....

c) the design, development, production, operation,

and use of aircraft .....

d) the exchange, by buying and selling, of goods;

business .....

e) the field or activity in which someone operates,

works, or takes interest .....

f) made very particular and specific, as a job or

field or study .....

g) customs and traditions considered as a whole

and as coming from one's ancestors .....

h) connection .....

i) a way or method enabling one to do something

(phrase) .....

j) understand (completely) .....

EXERCISE 2: Choose the correct answer according to the passage.

1. It is stated in the passage that English . . . . . .

A) is a second language used by all nations
B) has enabled England to spread its influence beyond its borders
C) is spoken by the majority of people in the world
D) is the only language used in specialized higher education
E) is not exclusively spoken at the United Nations

2. According to the passage, English as a second language . . . . . .

A) has increased its influence around the world due to its use in aviation
B) has strengthened its grip on international diplomacy
C) does not take the place of the mother tongue either culturally or emotionally
D) is most important in the world of commerce
E) is more important than a person's first language

3. We can infer from the passage that . . . . . .

A) English will soon be spoken by everyone in the world
B) many educational books and textbooks are written in English
C) England's political influence is constantly increasing
D) there would be no international diplomacy without English
E) people around the world would not have such similar interests without English

EXERCISE 3: Complete the sentences by selecting words from Column B in EXERCISE 1.

1. I'm sure his becoming so friendly with the boss's son is just……getting himself noticed for promotion.
2. My brother brought a kind of miniature violin back from Kenya, but it's more ornamental than it is……., because it doesn't actually make any sound at all.
3. Much as she would like to work overseas, she has such strong family…… that I don't think she could cope with being away for so long.
4. Although he works in the textiles industry, he doesn't actually work with textiles. Rather, his particular……is public relations.
5. Translation is a very……skill and requires more than just a good knowledge of both languages.